

The Good News

Elevation of the Holy Cross Orthodox Church, Sacramento

Rector's Reflection

As we now keep watch in the night to sing Thy praises as our Benefactor, O Christ, grant us forgiveness of what we have done in benighted delusion. Come provide a path that is easy to journey, that we may ascend upon it and find glory. - Canon, Nativity of our Lord Jesus Christ

Our journey to the Nativity of our Lord is a journey from darkness to light. The Word of God comes to be born as a little Child during a season when the Earth is cold and shrouded in darkness. This is not by chance. Jesus comes to us as Light in the darkness. ***I am the Light of the World***. The glad tidings of Christmas joy is this: that ***upon those who sat in the regions and shadow of death, a Light has dawned*** (Mt. 4:16). When it's dark out, we can't tell where to go. We become lost, we trip easily; it can feel lonely or frightening. But turn on even a small light, a flashlight perhaps, and we can find our way, we won't trip or feel so scared. On a grander scale, this is a metaphor for our condition and what Christ's coming means. Our sins darken our mind and our vision. Without God, we don't know what to do or where to go; we feel hopeless. But when the Light of Christ shines in our life – His words, His teaching, His abiding presence – then the darkness of sin and the fog of ignorance are cast away. In order to receive the Light of Christ, we need to cast off the weight of sin, the works of darkness, and receive Him with childlike joy. Jesus warns that some will reject Him by preferring darkness over light: ***And this is the condemnation, that the light has come into the world, and men loved darkness rather than light, because their deeds were evil.*** (Jn. 3:19) Jesus doesn't want to withhold His Light from us; He wants us to know the way and experience eternal joy! But we must invite Him into our lives, to make room in the inn of our hearts for the Christ Child. How? By repenting of our sins, giving thanks to God, and practicing generosity toward all. May we all be enlightened by His Uncreated Light, and rejoice with all our hearts that **CHRIST IS BORN!**



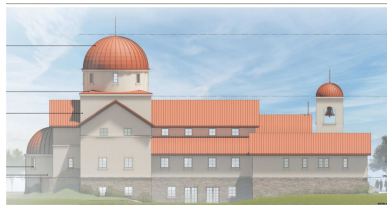
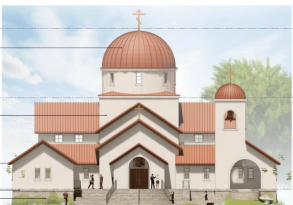
Feast Day & Hierarchical Visit

On our Parish Feast Day we joyfully welcomed our newly consecrated Bishop Vasily for the first time. Vladika Vasily was elected as Bishop of San Francisco and the Diocese of the West at the OCA's 21st All American Council in Phoenix last July. He was consecrated as a bishop at Holy Trinity Cathedral in San Francisco on August 16th, making his archpastoral visit to our parish among his first. Vladika Vasily is an accomplished scholar and theologian, having served as a Professor of Liturgical Theology at St. Vladimir's Seminary and at Holy Trinity Seminary. During the visit, Vladika ordained our Subdeacon John (Brett) Gainer to the diaconate, and gave an instructive and edifying homily on the Cross of our Lord Jesus Christ and the significance of this feast. May God bless and grant many years of fruitful ministry to our newly-consecrated Bishop Vasily and newly-ordained Deacon John!



Building Challenges & Progress!

Just about a year ago, we got news that our use permit hearing was delayed due to an Environmental Impact Report that still needed to be prepared. Glory to God, one year later, that report has been finally released for public comment. We're told we've met all the conditions necessary to go before the Sac. County Planning Commission, and are scheduled for a **January 12th Hearing** for our Use Permit. God willing, with that in hand, we can put the next phase of our project out for bids and get a clearer picture of the cost for each phase. We're hoping and praying to start moving dirt in Late Spring/Summer! Anticipating this, fundraising has remained strong! If we meet our Nativity Season Challenge of raising \$25,000, we will have raised over \$100,000 for the eighth consecutive year. This will put us in a good position to launch into the next phase. Please keep us in our prayers and consider supporting this holy work of building the future of Holy Cross!



Nativity Services & Upcoming Events

December 21 Caroling & Fellowship at the Duboviks

December 24 - *Eve of Nativity*

✦ 9:00 a.m. Royal Hours of Nativity

✦ 4:00 p.m. Vigil for Nativity

December 25 - *Nativity of Christ*

✦ 9:00 a.m. Divine Liturgy

January 25 - Annual Parish Meeting

9000 Jackson Rd, Sacramento, CA 95826 holycrosssacramento.org

Mailing: 2443 Fair Oaks Blvd #295, Sacramento, CA 95825

Archangel Michael Food Closet

Our **Archangel Michael Food Closet** continues to see record demand, distributing groceries to over seventy families a week now. At Thanksgiving, we gave out turkeys and groceries to over 200 families! We likewise provided back-to-school supplies for all school-age children, and are planning for a special Christmas distribution again as well. Glory to God, and much thanks to all of our volunteers and supporters from Holy Cross and St. Athanasius. Especially as demand has increased, you all have come through to continue to make this vital ministry possible.

American Orthodox

In July, we premiered a well-attended screening of our own John Hammond's film, **American Orthodox**. The film beautifully portrays the contemporary relevance and witness of our Orthodox Christian faith, while highlighting the enduring witness of saints like St. Peter the Aleut and local places of pilgrimage like Fort Ross. The discovery of a lost icon becomes symbolic of the discovery of the ancient yet ever-new treasure that is our Orthodox faith. Our own parish is featured in the film, together with other parishes, cathedrals and monasteries across Northern California. This film has already been recognized in a number of independent film festivals. Be sure to check it out if you haven't already! <https://americanorthodoxfilm.com/>

Memory Eternal, Michael!

It was with heavy hearts but firm hope in the Resurrection that we commended our dear brother-in-Christ, Michael Lahr, to the Lord. Michael was born on Dec. 7, 1980 in Santa Maria, and discovered the Orthodox Church during his time at UC Davis. He became and remained a faithful member of our parish and integral part of our community for two decades. A true and faithful friend, Michael was someone you could always count on not just to pray for you, but to help in any way he could, often beyond his strength. A gifted musician and linguist, he loved to sing in the choir and to learn new languages. He had a tremendous heart for sharing the faith, and dozens of people attribute their journeys to the Church to their conversations and friendships with Michael. He likewise became a godfather to many. Michael departed this life in his sleep Oct. 2nd, and we pray and trust he has found peace and blessed repose with God, and that he does not cease to remember us as we remember him. Memory Eternal!



Centennial Ft. Ross Pilgrimage

On Saturday, Oct. 4, 2025, God blessed Fort Ross State Historic Park and its environs with beautiful, calm, and sunny weather as over six hundred faithful gathered for the centennial celebration of our annual pilgrimage to Fort Ross. Met. Tikhon presided, together with Met. Nicholas of ROCOR and Met. Maximilian of Irkutsk, along with six other bishops and scores of concelebrating clergy. The day marked the 100th anniversary of the first pilgrimage to Fort Ross on July 4, 1925. Since that time, annual pilgrimages on the 4th of July have been organized by our Diocese of the West. This year's celebration began on Oct. 3 with a one-day conference at St. Seraphim of Sarov Cathedral, celebrating the history of Orthodox Christianity at Fort Ross. On Saturday, organizers and volunteers prepared the grounds of Fort Ross for the celebration by specially constructing a large holy table for the primatial divine liturgy, and transferring holy vessels, icons, bells, and a sound system to broadcast the litanies and exclamations across the interior of the Fort. Our own Valerie directed one of the two choirs, with many Holy Cross faithful participating in the pilgrimage and singing in the choir. After Liturgy, there was a Cross procession to the cemetery and Panikhida, and a festive luncheon. "It was magnificent celebrating this centennial pilgrimage here in this setting at the Fort, where many saints have prayed before us," Met. Tikhon noted, "A pilgrimage reminds us of how fleeting our life is and that we need to cling to things that are eternal." *Adapted from article on dowoca.org*